

Detail



Graphics cards have come a long way from the good old days when they just had to have a little processing power, and a few megabytes of RAM to augment the processing demanded of the CPU. The trend over the years has been to remove much of the load of graphics processing and rendering from the CPU to the GPU. So much so, that today's graphics cards are heavy-duty number crunchers that use much more advanced technology than other parts of the computer system. Today, you get graphics cards for almost every requirement, be it high-end or entry level, and at every level you have a mind boggling variety, as compared to the few that were available some time ago.

The 3D graphics card business is very competitive, and ATi has been a long-standing player. Previously, there wasn't too much competition because video games were generally 2D, and any run-

of-the-mill card was sufficient to play your favourite game—recall *Prince Of Persia* and *DOOM*. The entire scenario changed when games started going the 3D way, and 3DFx was the first company to take advantage of this situation. They developed their 3D video cards and their proprietary Glide API. ATi was still concentrating on the 2D market, along with Matrox. Then nVidia changed overnight, and after some stiff competition, bought 3DFx lock, stock and barrel, and are currently the king of the hill.

No one could deny the lucrative draw of the 3D market. ATi realised this a little later, and followed suit. Their first offerings in the 3D video card market did not get a good response, first because of drivers problem, and second because of the poor positioning of their products. nVidia trounced the ATi cards like no one else. Even Matrox did better. But in late 2000, ATi struck back with its Radeon chip. The technology that went into making the